

Leeway

2026, Luis Bolaños Mures, <https://boardgamegeek.com/boardgame/471008>

Leeway is a connection game for two players: Black and White. It is played on the intersections (points) of an initially empty square grid (board). The top and bottom edges of the board are colored black; the left and right edges are colored white.

Def. A **naked diagonal** is a pair of like-colored, diagonally adjacent stones with no other like-colored stone adjacent to both.

Black plays first, then turns alternate. On your turn, place two stones of your color on orthogonally adjacent empty points. Next, remove all other stones that form naked diagonals with the stones you just placed. If this creates more naked diagonals, remove one stone from each, and so on until no naked diagonals remain.

Alternatively, instead of placing two stones, you may place a single stone of your color on an empty point with no orthogonal adjacencies to empty points. No stones are removed in this case.

You win if there is a chain of orthogonally connected stones of your color touching the two opposite board edges of your color. If the position at the end of your turn is the same as the position at the end of any of your previous turns, the game ends in a draw. This is possible in theory, but probably requires colluding players.

To make the game fair, White will have the option, on their first turn only, to swap sides with Black instead of making a regular move, and Black is allowed to start the game with a single placement.

[BGG description]

Notes

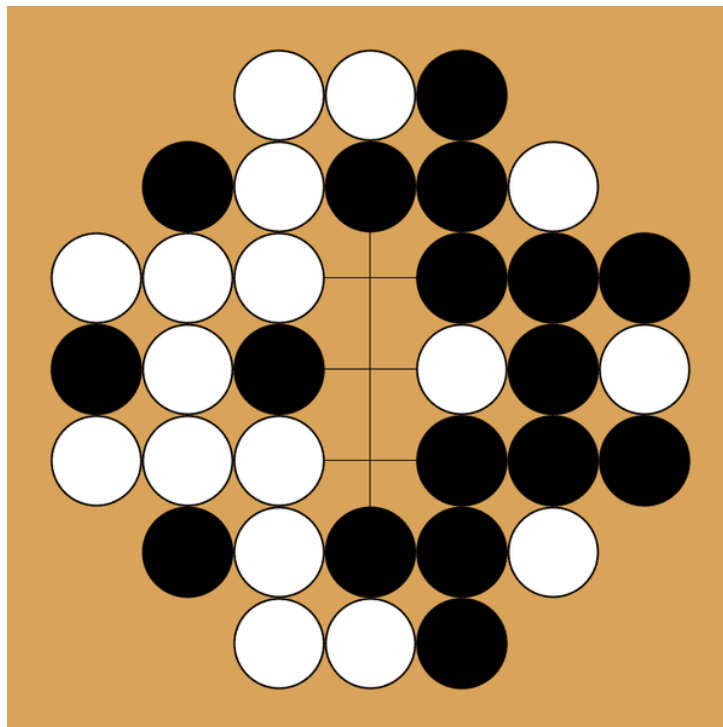
x . o	x o	x x
o . x	o . . x	o . . o
x . o	x . . o	o . . o
	o x	x x

From left to right: zipper, pinwheel, cartwheel.

I considered a [few ways](#) to make Leeway hard finite, but they all felt less elegant and original than simply removing stones in naked diagonals and relying on incentives to avoid cycles. Dominoes serve multiple purposes in this game:

- Make the game feel like Hex. Dominoes on a square board are adjacent to six points, like single pieces on a hexagonal board.

- Enable fixing most naked diagonals without captures. If naked diagonals are simply banned, random playouts on a 19×19 board with no win condition end with a less-than-full board just about 6% of the time. (All empty points left over in those cases are part of zippers and pinwheels. Unfortunately, banning those two deadlock patterns instead of allowing captures would introduce other [deadlock patterns](#).)
- Make the game finite in practice. A cycle requires that both players remove two stones per turn on average over at least two turns each. This is easy to conceive in theory but seems highly unrealistic in a competitive setting, as capturing more than one stone on your turn is rarely necessary or beneficial. Indeed, there are only a couple of contrived configurations in which every legal domino placement by either player requires removing more than one stone, and no domino placement ever requires removing more than three, although one may foolishly choose to remove more in even more contrived configurations.
- Avoid coldness and restriction overload. With single placements, avoiding naked diagonals feels very restrictive and makes cartwheels cold (without captures) or cyclic (with captures). With dominoes, the restriction turns into a gentle nudge and cartwheels become hot and finite.



The only configuration in which Black to move needs to remove more than two stones (namely three) and White to move needs to remove more than one (namely two).